

The Woof of The Underdog

No true home-theatre system can ever be complete without the addition of a high quality powerful sub-woofer. Its ability to produce rich and powerful bass, and low frequency sounds, not only enhances the surround effect in a multi-channel setup, but also gives the listener a more realistic and satisfying audio experience. Also, with the presence of a special low frequency effects (LFE) channel in both the Dolby and DTS digital surround formats, the sub-woofer becomes an essential element in a high-end digital audio system.

Sub-woofers are very distinct from ordinary speakers in terms of functionality and design. They are designed to specifically reproduce sounds with frequencies 80 Hz and below, such as the rumble of thunder, the growl of a tank's engine or explosions. To produce such low frequency tones, the woofer's driver has to vibrate slowly, and therefore, is comparatively larger than the other speakers. Therefore, the diameter of a normal sub-woofer is within the range of 8 to 12 inches. More powerful sub-woofers, with power outputs of nearly 800 W, have drivers measuring almost 18 inches across.

However, the catch with larger drivers is that as their size increases, the amount of power needed to operate them increases too. This can be rectified to an extent by providing an amplifier in the sub-woofer unit itself, but then the costs shoot up astronomically.



ity of sound. These speakers are truly a delight to listen to when you play a DVD. Not even the Creative GD580 could match it in terms of audio reproduction. The Artis did a pretty good job, along with Odyssey. The Megaworks' missing tweeters could not match the 5700D in terms of clarity, but the thump at high volumes is enough to make you reel. The Philips A3.610 put up a magnificent display, but again went tinny when turned up.

In our music tests, while playing *With or Without You*, the Artis X10 produced bass with an almighty thump, but the satellites couldn't complement the subwoofer. When we turned up the volume, the subwoofer pumped the bass higher, but the satellites almost killed the song. Much higher power rated satellites are required. Next, we moved on to the Creative Megaworks 5.1 550. The higher you go, the better it sounds. The satellites and subwoofer are completely in-sync. And the song couldn't have been played on much a better speaker to realize the percussions that it has. The Adcom speakers suffered from the same problem as the Artis. Turn up the volume, and the neighbours are sure to dial 100 and report the massacre of their eardrums by the under-powered satellites. The Odyssey also crashed, and burned at higher volumes. Ditto for the Philips A 3.610. In fact, its cousin—the A5.600—did better than the sleek flat panel speakers.

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